

Muskox

Ovibos moschatus

One of the few large mammals to roam the Arctic year round, the muskox is highly adapted to the cold. Its thick undercoat is covered by a coarse cloak of guard hairs over 24 in (60 cm) long, giving the animal its shaggy appearance. Its short, stocky legs and large hooves provide good traction on snow. The horns are used in defense and in dominance battles among bulls.

Musky males

Muskox herds are usually mixed-sex and can have 10 to more than 100 animals, although some bulls form bachelor herds or remain solitary. Herds are smaller from July to September, when dominant bulls control breeding harems of females. The bulls give off a musky odor during the mating season, giving the animal its name.

Muskox feed in lowland areas in summer, eating flowers in addition to their usual diet. In winter, they move to higher ground for easier foraging.

curved horns
almost meet in
middle of skull



- ↔ 6–8 ft (1.9–2.3 m)
- ⚖ 440–900 lb (200–410 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Sedges, grasses, leaves
- 🏠



N. North
America,
Greenland

▷ FACING THE ENEMY

When threatened by predators such as wolves or a polar bear, muskoxen form a circle and face outward.

Fighting bulls' collisions can be heard up to 1 mile (1.6 km) away



Caribou

Rangifer tarandus

Caribou (known as reindeer in Europe) are well adapted to life in the Arctic tundra. They have a dense coat and a broad muzzle that warms frigid air before it reaches the lungs. Caribou are strong swimmers, with broad, flat hooves. These provide stability on soft summer ground and act as snowshoes in winter, becoming harder and sharper-edged—ideal for cutting through snow and ice. Despite their broad hooves, they can run at up to 50 mph (80 km/h). They can see ultraviolet light, which helps them locate lichens and snow-covered vegetation on dark winter days.

On the move

Caribou are almost constantly on the move. Some migrate 3,000 miles (5,000 km) in a year—the longest distance any land mammal travels. Herds can be up to half a million strong, with smaller single-sex groups coming together to migrate during spring and fall. Males fight for control of harems of females in fall and the females give birth to a single calf in the next spring.

▽ COLOR VARIATION

High Arctic subspecies, such as the Peary caribou (*R. t. pearyi*), are smaller and lighter colored than caribou living at lower latitudes. Both male and female caribou have antlers that they shed and regrow each year.

- ↔ 4–7 ft (1.2–2.2 m)
- ⚖ 265–660 lb (120–300 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🌿 Leaves, roots, bark, lichen
- 🏠



N. North America, N. Europe,
N. Asia

branching
antlers

outer coat of wool-like hair
provides extra insulation

